

In their conclusion to *The Charisma Factor*, Richardson and Thayer have this to say: "There are many paths through the dark woods, but few are brave enough to walk them. Fewer still are those who believe so deeply in their own vision . . . that they risk saying 'Follow me' as they begin the journey." In spite of my criticisms of this book, I'm left with the feeling that it is well worth the read—for it not only can inspire us to speak the words "Follow me"—but it provides a broad range of advice, useful in encouraging others to respond to that invitation.

The Wisdom of Teams: Creating The High-Performance Organization

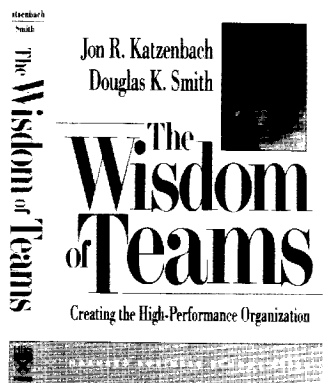
Reviewed by Karen L. Spencer, Johns Hopkins University

Book Review

A look in the current business literature indicates an increasing interest in using teams in today's workplace. In the plethora of books on teams and teaming, it is widely chronicled that work groups, labeled teams, can effectively accomplish more than individuals, and that through working in teams, employees will be more motivated and energized. Each of us has grown up hearing the old adage that states, "two (or more) heads are better than one." All of these indicators would seem to point the way toward creating teams in organizations to increase productivity. Sometimes in organizations, however, "doing teams" has taken on the same superficial meaning and hollow promise as the old Hollywood phrase of "doing lunch." Everyone talks about it, but what really comes of the promise? Part of the problem, according to Jon Katzenbach and Douglas Smith in their new book, *The Wisdom of Teams*, is that team is a word and concept that is familiar to everyone, yet holds many different personal meanings. To find out how and if teams really support some of the widely held beliefs about them, Katzenbach and Smith interviewed hundreds of people working in fifty teams across thirty companies and organizations.

The executive in a rush could read the prologue of the book to discover the authors' major findings on teams. That would, however, be like eating an orange for the pulp and skipping the juice. The authors convey their findings through stories about people in organizations who are actively involved in teaming. These stories represent a wide variety of performance challenges, types of people, and organizational environments. The authors draw out what they call some "common sense findings," and some "uncommon sense findings" to help those who consider adopting team concepts and who want to understand their nature, the process of becoming a team, and exploit the potential of teams in their own organizations.

There is a primary common sense finding that Katzenbach and Smith reinforce throughout the book: Teams must have a demanding performance challenge to create and sustain themselves. It doesn't matter if the organization or the team itself identifies the performance challenge, as long as the team adopts it. The first uncommon sense finding is the corollary to the first common sense finding:



**By Jon R. Katzenbach
and Douglas K. Smith**
Boston, MA: Harvard
Business School Press
1993, 291 pages, \$24.95

"Real" high performance teams that are formed or form spontaneously don't focus on the goal of "becoming teams." While many executives advocate teamwork (and they should), teamwork in itself is not the reason for the productivity of teams. Teamwork behavior and values such as active listening, responding constructively to the views expressed by others, dealing with controversy constructively, and supporting and recognizing team members help a team perform, but the values and behaviors by themselves are not exclusive to teams, nor are they sufficient to ensure team performance. Real teams form best when management makes clear performance demands. Most important, groups of people do not become teams just because they are called teams, or because they are sent off to team-building workshops.

The authors define team in the following way:

A team is a small number of people with complementary skills who are committed to a common purpose, set of performance goals, and approach for which they hold themselves accountable.

In other words, while a demanding performance challenge is essential to the formation and sustenance of teams, it is not sufficient. Successful teams have attended to team basics: appropriate size; clear purpose and goals; sufficient interpersonal and group skills; a shared approach; and individual and mutual accountability.

In studying successful teams, the authors found that team performance opportunities exist in all parts of the organization in different types of work groups: teams that recommend things (e.g., task forces), teams that make or do things (e.g., worker teams, sales teams), and teams that run things (management teams at various levels). Two common sense realities provide the reason that teams are not often used at all levels: teams at the top are most difficult to form and sustain because of the complexity of long-term challenges, heavy demands on executive time, and ingrained individualism of senior people. Secondly, most organizations intrinsically prefer individual over team or group accountability. Our culture of the "rugged individualist" is supported and reinforced by job descriptions, compensation schemes, career paths, and performance evaluations focused on individuals. Yet, effective team leaders shift from a focus on individualism to a focus on teams who are collectively responsible for maintaining individual and team performance standards.

Despite the culture of individualism in most organizations, the stories the authors relate clearly support the assertion that teams outperform individuals acting alone or in larger organizational groupings, especially when their performance requires multiple skills, judgments, and experiences. In fact, individual performance within groups is heightened by the teams' desire to meet their performance challenge. One of the uncommon sense findings also shows that teaming does not have to wreak havoc with the hierarchical structures of organizations. According to the authors, "Hierarchy and teams go together almost as well as teams and performance. . . . Teams, in fact, are the best way to integrate across structural boundaries and to both design and energize core processes. Those who see teams as a replacement for hierarchy are missing the true potential of teams."

Most organizations want to be known as "learning organizations." One of the last uncommon sense findings is that teams naturally integrate performance

and learning. Teams are necessarily made up of highly committed individuals who seek out what they need to know to get their job done. They translate longer term purposes into definable performance goals and then develop the skills needed to meet those goals. So while technical and interpersonal skills are required, teams need to develop them in response to the working needs of the group, not as an end in themselves.

The key to unleashing the wisdom of teams lies in an organization's willingness to recognize their unique potential to deliver results and understand the benefits they provide: development of individual members, team accomplishments, and superior company-wide performance. The authors grant that while the team option promises greater performance results, it also brings more risk. The price of faking a team approach either by intention or ineptitude is high. Employees resent the imposition on their time and priorities and the diversion from their individual goals; costs can outweigh benefits; and serious animosities and distrust develop in the organization that can undercut morale and productivity. However, Katzenbach and Smith sum up their feelings about deciding on the team option in the following ways:

We have listened carefully to all the logical reasons for not pursuing team options, many of which are rational and understandable if not compelling. Yet while we respect this reluctance, we are not dissuaded from our basic contention: most of the objections to pursuing the use of teams do not offset the advantages they offer. . . . In the end, the wisdom of teams is within itself. . . . It is in a small group of people so committed to something larger than themselves that they will not be denied.

This superb book is a required addition to the library of anyone who wishes to support the development of teams in his or her organization. While the authors offer no guaranteed recipe for creating and sustaining teams, they do provide insight into and evidence of how successful teams work. One cannot help but be drawn into the stories they relate and the analysis that naturally follows on what seems to work and not work in each team's effort to meet its performance challenge. This book gives a sense of real people in real contexts who not only meet their performance challenges, but also meet and enjoy the considerable challenges and benefits of working on a high-performance team.

Executive Development: Preparing for the 21st Century

Reviewed by Henry H. Beam, Western Michigan University

Book Review

Executive development is a relatively new branch of education. Since World War II it has developed into a major industry in its own right. It constitutes a wide variety of learning experiences with a common purpose—helping managers grow in competence throughout their careers. Executive development programs are typically full-time, intensive and expensive, so it is important for corporations to select executives who will benefit from attending. Most